

INSIDE: Former Carolina coach Dom Capers will coach the expansion Houston NFL franchise in 2002. **3-D**

THE PLAIN DEALER SPORTS

SATURDAY, JANUARY 20, 2001 | SECTION D**



BUD SHAW

Fairness lost in PGA fairways

Mark Twain called golf "a good walk spoiled."

For Casey Martin, there's no such thing. That's because there's no such thing as a good walk.

He might well lose his leg someday to Klippel-Trenaunay-Weber Syndrome, a progressive vascular disease that causes him sharp, constant pain. To those who believe riding a golf cart gives him an unfair advantage on the PGA Tour, he says, "Walk a mile in my shoes."

They couldn't, of course. Neither can he, not without speeding the disease's debilitating effects.

Players who've shared four-somes with Martin say the walk from the cart to the greens seems as much an effort for him as walking tee-to-green does for them. He has never won a PGA Tour event. He finished 179th on the money list last year.

If there is some great advantage to Martin playing on one leg, it's a perceived rule-book advantage. In reality, there is no evidence of one. The cart he rides doesn't make his life on tour spectacularly improved at the expense of other golfers. The cart he rides makes playing on tour possible.

There was a human decision, a right decision, a common-sense decision to make in Martin's case long ago. But the PGA Tour missed that opportunity. And this week, after the Supreme Court heard arguments in the PGA's appeal, you sensed that the opportunity missed will cost Martin his dream of matching shots with the world's best golfers.

As a Supreme Court case, Martin can't help but get depersonalized. He's a dimpled chad, a recount deadline, an American with a disability not unlike all Americans with disabilities.

Martin is actually one in a million. He qualified for the Tour because his skills were ample enough to qualify him. Nobody let him subtract strokes because of his leg. He had to make all the shots to reach the tour.

Carts, incidentally, are used in qualifying events and also on the Senior Tour.

The PGA Tour's argument is two-pronged. One point is that the Americans with Disabilities Act is not intended to apply to participants. The other is that walking is an integral aspect of championship golf.

My guess is the first argument probably amounts to Martin's undoing. It's a stretch to apply the ADA to the particular rules of a sport. The broader the stretch the greater the court's reluctance to set precedent.

But how fundamentally integral is walking to the nature of golf? Anybody who has walked 18 holes as a spectator on a hot final round in August knows that endurance is part of the round. We're not talking the endurance of a marathon runner, though. And in Casey Martin, we're not talking about a guy with a bothersome hip.

Justice John Paul Stevens wondered how integral walking was to golf, asking how walking "can be a fundamental rule and not apply in the qualifying events." He went on to say that if "logistics are sufficient to justify the use of a cart, why isn't a handicap sufficient?"

How fundamental is it when carts are sometimes used to shuttle players from green to tee to speed up play?

Golf is a game of skill, nerves, concentration, strategy and, yes, even fitness. In that order. The PGA Tour is defending its right to make its own rules. Its answer to the Supreme Court was that when carts are used they are used for everybody.

Fine. So if Casey Martin's exceptional situation doesn't qualify as an exception, then in tournaments where he rides give golfers who feel disadvantaged the option to use a cart.

The PGA could have done that without opening the door to a thousand Casey Martins demanding special accommodation. The first requirement for a tour card is exceptional skill.

But the PGA didn't do it. And now a ruling against Martin means a good golf career, an inspiring golf career, is spoiled.

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By MARY SCHMITT BOYER

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

DENVER — Chris Gatling was critiquing the Cavaliers' gummy performance in their 91-88 loss to the Denver Nuggets last night in Pepsi Center.

"Overall, I'd give us a B," he said.

Unfortunately, the Cavs would much rather have had a W.

They gave themselves a chance in what turned out to be a wildly entertaining game. They were

Another good effort, another loss as Cavs end 1-5 trek

within 89-88 after two free throws by Jim Jackson with 13.8 seconds left, and within 91-88 after two foul shots by Denver's Nick Van Exel with 11.2 seconds left.

But neither Lamond Murray nor Jackson could sink a 3-pointer in the final seconds and the Cavs lost for the 13th time in 16 games to fall to 18-20. They

closed out this 11-day trip with a 1-5 record.

"They made some plays down the stretch," Cavs coach Randy Wittman said of the Nuggets, who have been playing almost as well as any team in the league. "They made one more than we could."

As a result, the Nuggets won their seventh straight game at home, their 14th in the last 18

overall, to improve to 24-16.

"I don't know how Lamond Murray missed that shot," Denver coach Dan Issel said. "He's usually lights out. We were lucky he missed tonight. We dodged a big bullet."

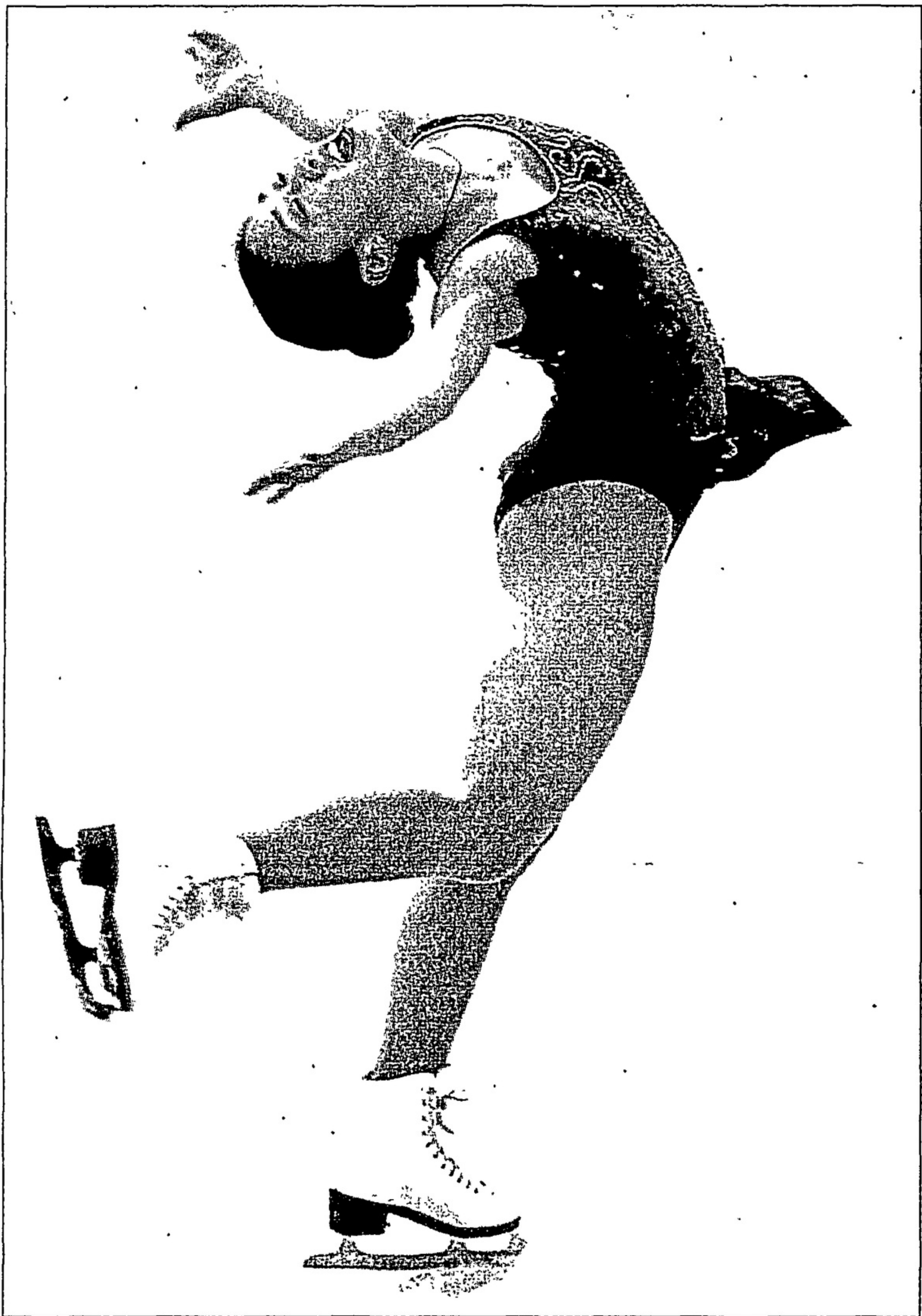
"We struggle against teams like this. Teams like Miami and Cleveland give us trouble because they won't run with us and

they play physical. It's good to know that when we don't play good basketball we can still win."

Indeed, the Nuggets were far off the pace they set in the past two games, when they scored a total of 243 points and hit 28 3-pointers. They hit 6 of 18 3-pointers last night, and made 33 of 76 field goals overall. Their 43.4 shooting percentage was a low for a Cavs opponent on this trip.

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U.S. FIGURE SKATING CHAMPIONSHIPS



CHARLES KRUPA / ASSOCIATED PRESS

Stylish and in complete control, Michelle Kwan wowed fans and judges with a near-flawless short program during the U.S. Figure Skating Championships last night in Boston.

'Sweet' skate: Kwan floats to early lead

By AMY ROSEWATER

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

BOSTON — If there weren't banners hanging from the rafters of the FleetCenter celebrating the achievements of the Celtics and the Bruins, you would have thought you were in Philadelphia last night.

The freedom with which Michelle Kwan floated across the ice in her short

program was so reminiscent of her performance in the 1998 U.S. Figure Skating Championships in Philadelphia that seven of the judges even gave her the same scores — perfect 6.0's.

"I think it was just as good," said Kwan, the leader after the short program. "I think the music itself and just being in the moment. It's what all skaters dream about doing — feeling that sweet spot."

The top seven skaters turned in clean programs and the event didn't even include three of the nation's top young stars in Naomi Nar Nam (hip), Sasha Cohen (back) and Deanna Stellato (hip).

Kwan, who is now four and a half minutes away from winning her fifth national title, just hopes her sequel to Philadelphia will end as it did three years ago. Back in 1998, after skating an equally magnificent short program to Rachmaninoff, Kwan performed a flowing long program and earned eight perfect scores.

And to think that Kwan almost

Year-long quest ends with gold for Pennington

BOSTON — After losing the national crown on the marks of a single judge a year ago in Cleveland, Parker Pennington yesterday won the junior championship at the U.S. Figure Skating Championships in Boston.

Pennington was third after the short program, but vaulted to first with a strong overall performance in the free skate. Ben Miller of St. Paul, Minn., was second.

"Going into the short program, I wanted to win and I tried way too hard," said Pennington, 16, of Westlake. "Before I skated today, my coaches Carol [Heiss Jenkins] and Glyn [Watts] said, 'Just have fun.' During the whole program I didn't think about one thing."

Pennington received first-place marks from eight of the nine judges.

More coverage. 6-D

didn't skate this particular short program at all. Earlier this season, Kwan's short program music was to an Eric Clapton collection from the movie, "Rush." Olympic dance champion Christopher Dean choreographed the program and received mixed reviews at Skate America and Skate Canada.

SEE KWAN/8-D

HIGH SCHOOL BOYS BASKETBALL

Avon Lake escapes with last-second win

By EDDIE DWYER

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Leaning against the wall in Olmsted Falls' gymnasium, Avon Lake coach Dave Olinger had a look of disbelief.

"I don't think that's the way you draw it up on the board, but it's sure the way you dream about it," Olinger said.

Thanks to some last-minute heroics by senior guard Brian Ingleright, junior forward Tom Port and freshman guard Corey Jones, Olinger's dream became reality last night.

The Shoremen, on the strength of three baskets by Ingleright in the final 1:30, including the game-winner as time expired, rallied to defeat Olmsted Falls, 72-70, in a Southwestern Conference boys basketball game.

Avon Lake, ranked 17th in this week's Plain Dealer Top 25, improved to 11-1, 7-0 in the SWC. Olmsted Falls, the area's 19th-ranked team, fell to 6-4, 6-1.

"Right now, it's just hard for me to believe that we won this game," Olinger said. "But any time you can come over here

and come away with a win, we'll take it."

Olinger's Shoremen took it home just when it appeared that Olmsted Falls had done enough to secure the victory.

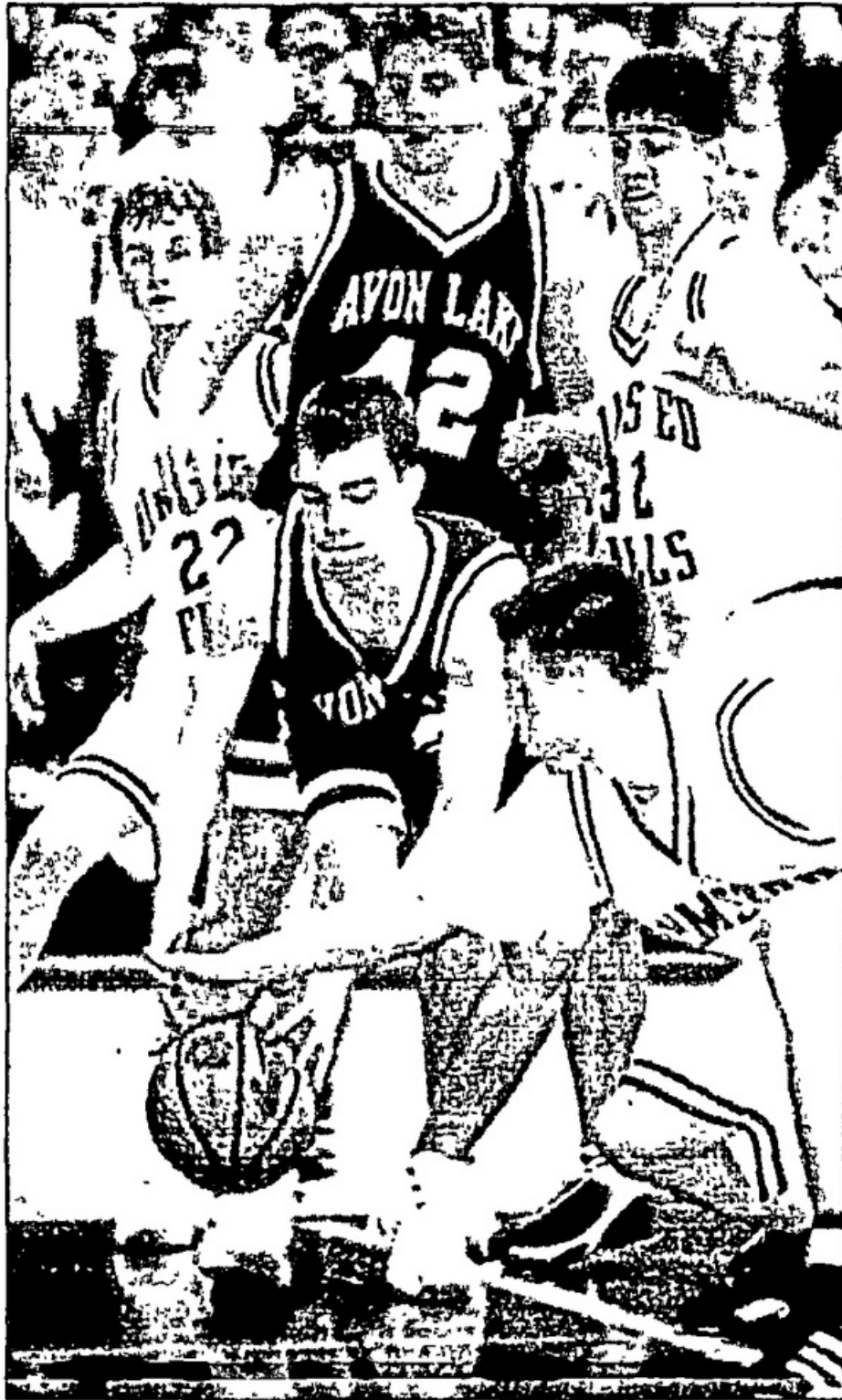
The Bulldogs, who have won five consecutive SWC titles, led, 70-66, after senior guard Joe Stanton hit a running left-hander high off the glass with 1:37 remaining.

But Ingleright, who needs 29 points to become Avon Lake's all-time leading scorer, put back a shot and the Shoremen called a timeout trailing, 70-68, with 1:10 left.

Following a timeout by Olmsted Falls with 44 seconds to go, Ingleright came up with a steal. It was a play that saw the crafty floor general tip the ball to Jones, who passed it right back to him for a breakaway layup and the tying basket with 36 seconds remaining.

In the final 30 seconds, it was no secret who Bulldogs coach Pat Donahue was going to call on.

SEE ESCAPES/9-D



LONNIE TIMMONS III / THE PLAIN DEALER

Olmsted Falls' Mike Gansey, right, tries to knock the ball away from Marc Jungermann during Avon Lake's last-second victory last night.

Browns line up five interviews, add Tice to list

By TONY GROSSI

PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

The Browns have five interviews for their coaching job scheduled next week. A sixth, long-shot candidate emerged yesterday: Mike Tice, offensive line coach of the Minnesota Vikings.

But Carmen Policy said he will wait to interview Baltimore Ravens defensive coordinator Marvin Lewis after the Super Bowl before deciding on the next Browns head coach. Policy also said he may interview both coordinators of the New York Giants, Sean Payton on offense and John Fox on defense, but has not sought permission to do so.

The latest developments in the Browns' coaching search are these:

■ Tice was added to the list after a strong recommendation from Vikings coach Dennis Green. Tice, 42, is a former NFL tight end whose coaching career has been on the rise for five years under Green.

■ Policy will interview Browns defensive coordinator Romeo Crennel early in the week. The Browns CEO said he wants to assure Crennel's place in the organization even if he is not promoted to head coach.

SEE BROWNS/3-D

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